continuous focus on. In the TZ20 the colours in indoor shooting were quite vivid and panning in the S8200 was not as jerky as what was observed in the Nikon P7100. As far as the Canon cameras went, the quality in the 1080p clips was much better than that in the 720p mode.

In the outdoor shooting scene, the SX220HS and SX230HS were quickly able to adjust the in-camera lighting based on the shadows. Image stabilization was good while panning, even at the telephoto end. Overall detailing in the leaves on the trees and surrounding buildings was good. With the Nikon S8200, noise suppression was much better, but focus hunting was still quite evident. With the TZ20, panning vertically at the telephoto end was quite jerky. We noticed jaggies in the output while panning horizontally.

Verdict
The award for the Best Buy was bagged by the Canon Powershot SX230HS for its consistent performance across all the tests. It also had a healthy mix of features. If you look at the overall scores, there was decent competition among all the competitors. If you do not want the GPS functionality, you should go for the SX 220HS which is identical to SX230HS and is priced lower for the same overall features and performance output.

Ultrazooms
An ultrazoom camera walks a fine line between being an SLR and a point and shoot. Compared to an SLR, they have smaller sensors, no mirror or an optical viewfinder. The lens optics will normally not be too great either and is a very important factor to consider when picking a camera in this category. What you do get is a fairly large camera, the functionality of a DSLR, and a long zoom.

Features and Design
We received six cameras for this test and the first thing that struck us was the size of these cameras. All of them were almost as large as full-fledged DSLRs and heavy as well. The Nikon L120 was the smallest of the lot, but the design is such that it is a little heavy for single-handed use, but too small to use comfortably with both hands. The Finepix HS20 EXR and the Sony HX100V were the only cameras to feature control rings on the front. The HS20 EXR was a notch ahead and provided a focus ring as well as a zoom ring, also, the zoom on the HS20 EXR is mechanically controlled unlike the electronic control on the HX100V. All the other cameras had traditional zoom controls, except the Nikons, which include additional thumb-switches on the lens.

All the cameras except the Finepix S3300 and Nikon Coolpix L120 had articulated displays, with only the Canon SX40 HS having a fully articulated display that could be flipped as well as rotated. All other displays were just hinged at one or two fixed points. All the cameras except the Coolpix L120 had Electronic View Finders. The Finepix HS20 EXR and Sony DSC-HX100V have proximity sensors next to the EVF and switch to it automatically when the sensor is covered. All the other cameras have buttons to switch between the LCD and the EVF. One thing to note is that the refresh rate of the EVF and LCD on the Finepix S3300 seemed to be a bit low as the response was very sluggish.

The cameras all featured some sort of panorama mode or the other. The mode on the Fujifilm camera works by taking three individual shots and stitching them together. The first shot is aligned by the user, the other two are taken automatically when you line up certain markers on the screen. The Canon camera features a panorama assist mode where it will keep a bit of each picture in the frame, to help you line up your next shot. The Sony and Nikon cameras feature a sweep panorama mode. This mode is much easier to use, but more difficult to master at the same time. Of all the above methods tested, by far the most accurate results were to be had from the Nikon and Fujifilm cameras.

Coming to ergonomics, the Finepix HS20 EXR again stands out. It has a plethora of extra buttons and most of the regularly used functions are easily available at hand instead of digging into the menus and also includes an extra dial for adjusting settings. Barring the L120, the cameras all had mode dials, with all of them having the facility of accessing a custom preset from the dial itself. In hand, the cameras were all comfortable to hold and shoot, but the two Nikon's felt a bit cramped in comparison, especially the L120.

Performance
The Canon SX40HS aced the high-ISO tests, producing clean images upto almost ISO800. Noise does creep in at ISO400 itself, but it is barely noticeable, but even ISO800 is usable. The worst performers were the Nikon L120 and the Finepix S3300. The noise reduction on the S3300 started blurring out details at even ISO400, with ISO800 and above being extremely noisy. In fact, ISO800 on the S3300 was worse than ISO3200 on the SX40 HS. The Ninon P500 and the HS20EXR performed quite well, performing almost at par with the SX40 HS. ISO1600 onwards is barely usable on any of the cameras and, it goes without saying, ISO3200 and 6400 are only for emergencies, the quality is that bad.

The Canon SX40 HS again aced the sharpness tests as well, managing to capture detail in all areas of our test shot. The L120 was also almost as good, but lost out on detail in the darker areas of the image. The Finepix HS20 EXR was much worse off, the text on the PCB was barely legible and the threads were patchy in many areas, with a complete lack of detail on the black and white threads.

All the cameras except the Finepix HS20 EXR fared well in the macro test, with both the Sony HX100V and the Finepix S3300 showing a lot of detail at a 100 percent crop. Almost all the images were subject to a certain degree of barrel distor-

PARANORMAL ACTIVITY
During the testing we noticed a couple of unusual things. The L120 had some trouble reading the two Sandisk memory cards that we had though the other cameras didn't seem to have any problem with them. The other issue was with the Fujifilm Finepix HS20, which suddenly threw up a "!Frame no. full" error message while our resident photographer was out clicking. A quick internet search revealed that this is an issue prevalent among certain Fujifilm cameras and the only solution is to format the card, after taking a backup of course, and then resetting the "Frame no." option in the menu of the camera to "Renew"